

THE PATRIARCH OF THE WAR MACHINE

Samuel Prescott Bush, The War Industries Board & The Genesis of Dynastic Military Profiteering

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FORENSIC INVESTIGATIVE DIRECTIVE: Modern American dynastic political power was not forged in civic town halls or ideological debates; it was engineered on the foundry floors of Gilded Age steel monopolies, in the smoke-filled procurement backrooms of World War I, and through the early institutional architecture of the military-industrial complex. At the precise center of this historical pivot stands **Samuel Prescott Bush (1863–1948)**. As President of Buckeye Steel Castings Company (a corporate satellite of the Rockefeller oil and rail empire) and simultaneously the Chief of the Ordnance, Small Arms, and Ammunition Section of Woodrow Wilson's War Industries Board (WIB) under Wall Street financier Bernard Baruch, Samuel P. Bush established the model of corporate-state self-dealing. This manual deconstructs the corporate ledgers, procurement archives, labor suppression files, and federal investigation records that prove how the Bush dynasty converted battlefield carnage into dynastic financial and political dominance.

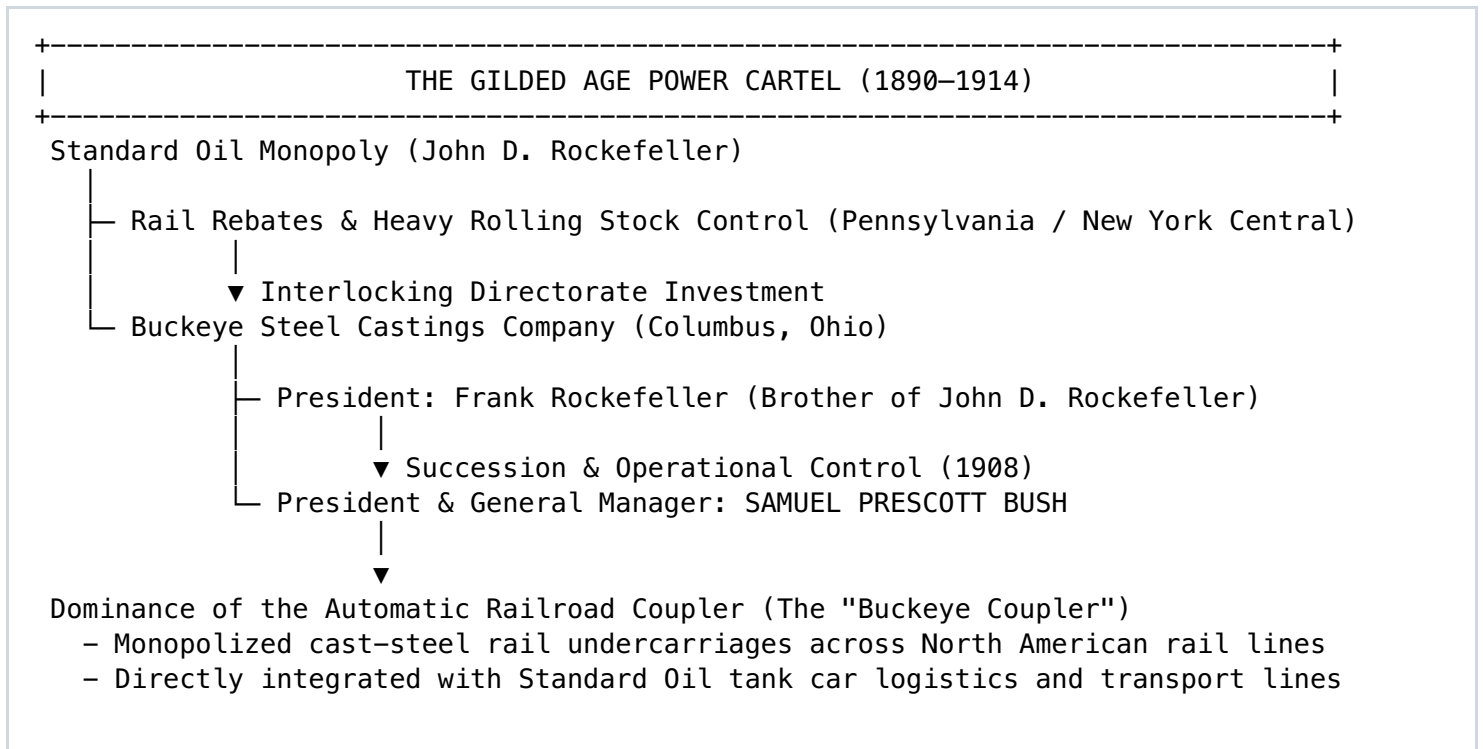
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1. THE GILDED AGE FOUNDRY: BUCKEYE STEEL & RAILROAD TRUSTS

Samuel Prescott Bush was born into the ascendant Northeastern managerial elite in Brick Church, New Jersey, in 1863, the son of an Episcopal clergyman. Educated at the Stevens Institute of Technology—one of the earliest specialized engineering colleges in the United States—Bush studied mechanical engineering, focusing on rail metallurgy, steam power, and foundry mechanics.

Following an early career with the Pennsylvania Railroad under the tutelage of Alexander Cassatt (brother to the painter Mary Cassatt and vice president of the line), Bush moved to Columbus, Ohio, in 1901 to assume the general managership of **Buckeye Steel Castings Company** (formerly the Buckeye Malleable Iron and Coupler Company).



Buckeye Steel was not an ordinary independent foundry; it was an industrial satellite of the Rockefeller corporate network. Frank Rockefeller served as its president until a bitter internal rift with his brother, after which Samuel P. Bush took executive command of the board in 1908. Under Bush, Buckeye grew into one of the largest industrial employers in Ohio, utilizing advanced open-hearth furnaces to cast high-tensile steel couplers, truck frames, and heavy rolling-stock parts essential for continental freight transport.

2. THE PIVOT TO INDUSTRIAL MUNITIONS: METALLURGICAL CONVERSION

When the European powers plunged into World War I in August 1914, American heavy industry underwent a swift transition. With British and French capital rapidly depleting their domestic stockpiles, J.P. Morgan & Company was appointed the sole purchasing agent in the United States for the British and French war offices.

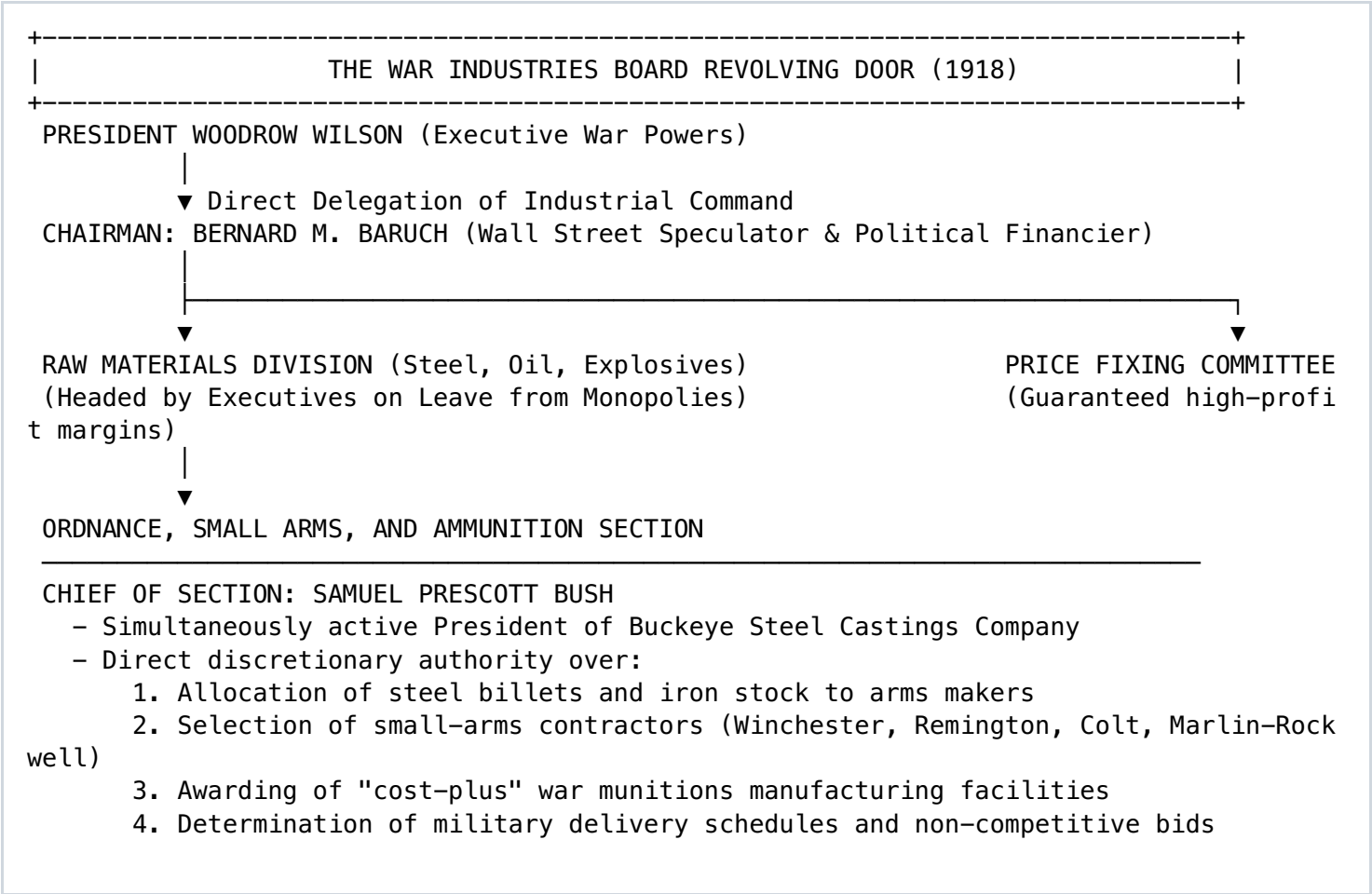
Samuel Bush recognized that modern trench warfare was an industrial artillery battle characterized by high metallurgical consumption. Buckeye Steel adapted its open-hearth casting pits from casting heavy railroad couplers to forging artillery shells, bomb casings, gun forgings, and specialized railway infrastructure required to transport heavy ordnance to Atlantic shipping ports.

Company / Industrial Entity	Pre-War Production (1913)	Wartime Munitions Shift (1915–1918)	Primary Financial / Political Alignment
Buckeye Steel Castings (S.P. Bush)	Railway couplers, freight trucks, side frames	Cast-steel shell casings, gun mount components, rail mounts	Rockefeller / Western Rail Trust / War Industries Board
Remington Arms-UMC	Sporting rifles, civilian shotguns	Pattern 1914 Enfield, M1917 Enfield, billions of rounds	J.P. Morgan & Co. Allied Purchasing Agent
Bethlehem Steel (Charles Schwab)	Armor plate, commercial structural beams	High-explosive naval shells, field guns, naval armor	Allied Munitions Syndicates / War Industries Board
Winchester Repeating Arms	Lever-action repeating rifles	Military contract small arms, Browning Automatic Rifles (BAR)	Ordnance Division / US Government Cost-Plus Contracts

3. BERNARD BARUCH’S SHADOW CABINET: THE WAR INDUSTRIES BOARD

When the United States formally entered World War I in April 1917, the federal government faced an unprecedented logistical crisis: chaotic procurement, runaway wartime commodity inflation, railway transport gridlock, and price-gouging by private contractors competing against one another for military supplies.

In response, President Woodrow Wilson concentrated economic authority in an emergency administrative organ: the **War Industries Board (WIB)**, established in July 1917 and overhauled in March 1918 under the absolute chairmanship of Wall Street speculative financier **Bernard M. Baruch**.



The Institutional Conflict of Interest

Under Baruch’s model, the War Industries Board was composed not of neutral civil servants, but of the corporate leaders whose industries were receiving war contracts—the so-called "dollar-a-year men." Samuel P. Bush was brought into this command network, first as head of the Facilities Division and subsequently appointed directly by Baruch as **Chief of the Ordnance, Small Arms, and Ammunition Section**.

In this role, Bush held federal power to direct the supply of raw metals, determine which private manufacturing plants would be converted to wartime munitions production, and approve the multi-million-dollar government procurement orders that flowed to arms and steel firms across the United States.

4. CHIEF OF ORDNANCE: CONTROLLING SMALL ARMS PROCUREMENT

The Ordnance Section was the industrial core of the American war effort. Between 1917 and 1918, the United States government spent over **\$4 billion on ordnance** (equivalent to roughly \$90 billion today)—more than the combined annual operating cost of the entire federal government prior to the conflict.

National Archives Record Group 61: Records of the War Industries Board

Executive Minutes • Ordnance Section • Chief: Samuel P. Bush

"The Chief of the Section is charged with determining the capacity of the country to manufacture small arms, ammunition, and corresponding ordnance supplies; to allocate priority requirements among competing manufacturers; to eliminate non-essential commercial production; and to recommend financial advances for plant extensions."

Historical Reality: Samuel P. Bush possessed regulatory oversight over the exact corporate syndicates that purchased high-tensile steel, shell forgings, and components from suppliers like Buckeye Steel Castings, creating a closed procurement loop.

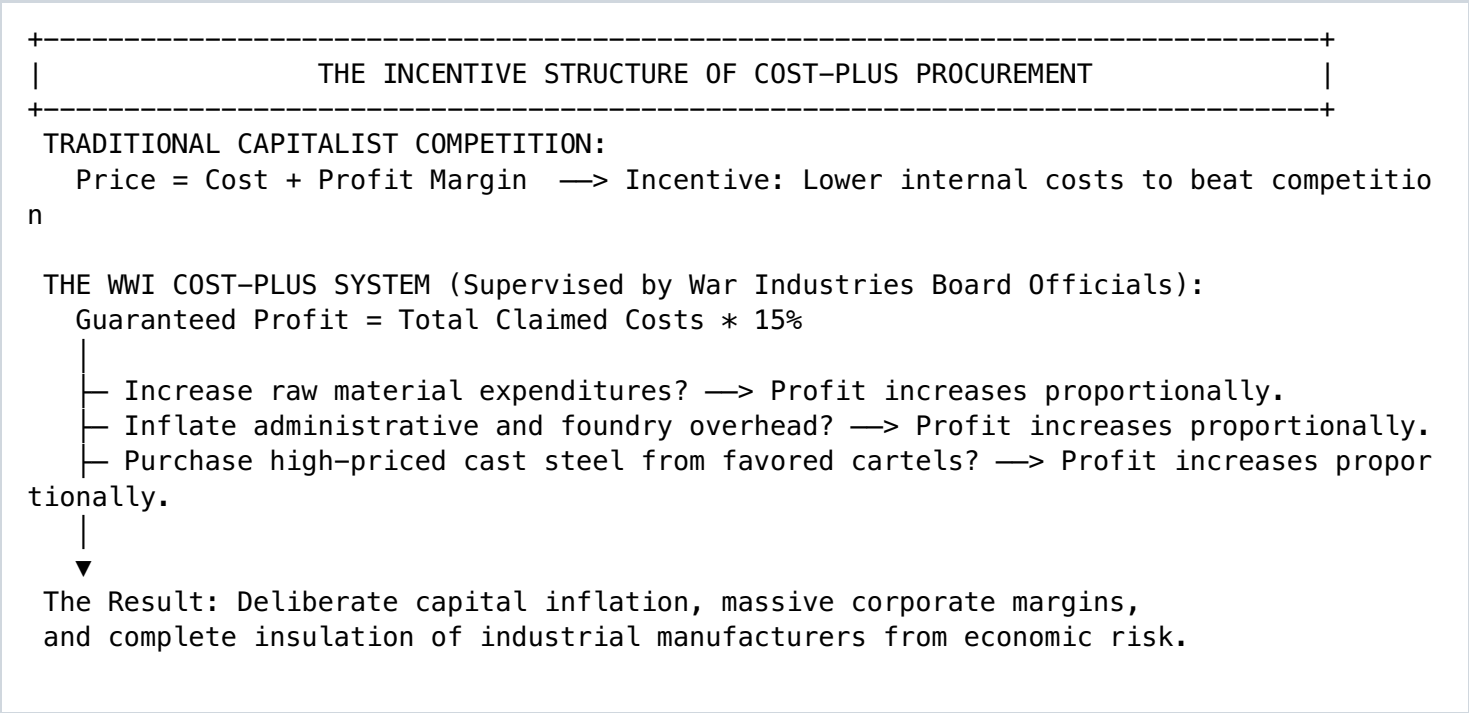
The Standardization of Armaments and Price Fixing

Under Bush's authority, the production of the **Model 1917 Enfield rifle** and the **Browning Automatic Rifle (BAR)** was concentrated within a tight syndicate of manufacturers: Winchester, Remington, and Colt. Bush worked directly with the Council of National Defense and the War Department's Ordnance Bureau to approve "plant expansion loans" funded by taxpayers.

These government funds built modern, private industrial factories that remained in corporate hands after the armistice, establishing the precedent of public risk underwriting private corporate assets.

5. THE ANATOMY OF WAR PROFITEERING: COST-PLUS CONTRACTS

The financial mechanism that enriched industrial manufacturers during World War I was the **Cost-Plus-Percentage-of-Cost (CPPC) contract**. Under this procurement framework, the federal government agreed to pay a munitions contractor the entire verified cost of manufacturing their product, plus a guaranteed, legally protected profit margin (typically 10% to 15% on top of all claimed costs).



Munitions / Steel Corporation	Average Annual Pre-War Net Profit (1911–1914)	Peak War Net Profit (1917)	Percentage Net Profit Surge
United States Steel Corporation	\$46,165,000	\$224,219,000	+385%
Bethlehem Steel Company	\$4,250,000	\$61,200,000	+1,340%
DuPont Powder Company	\$5,400,000	\$82,000,000	+1,418%
Buckeye Steel Castings (S.P. Bush)	Stable Regional Dividend	Record Wartime Capitalization	Funded Bush dynastic expansion into Wall Street

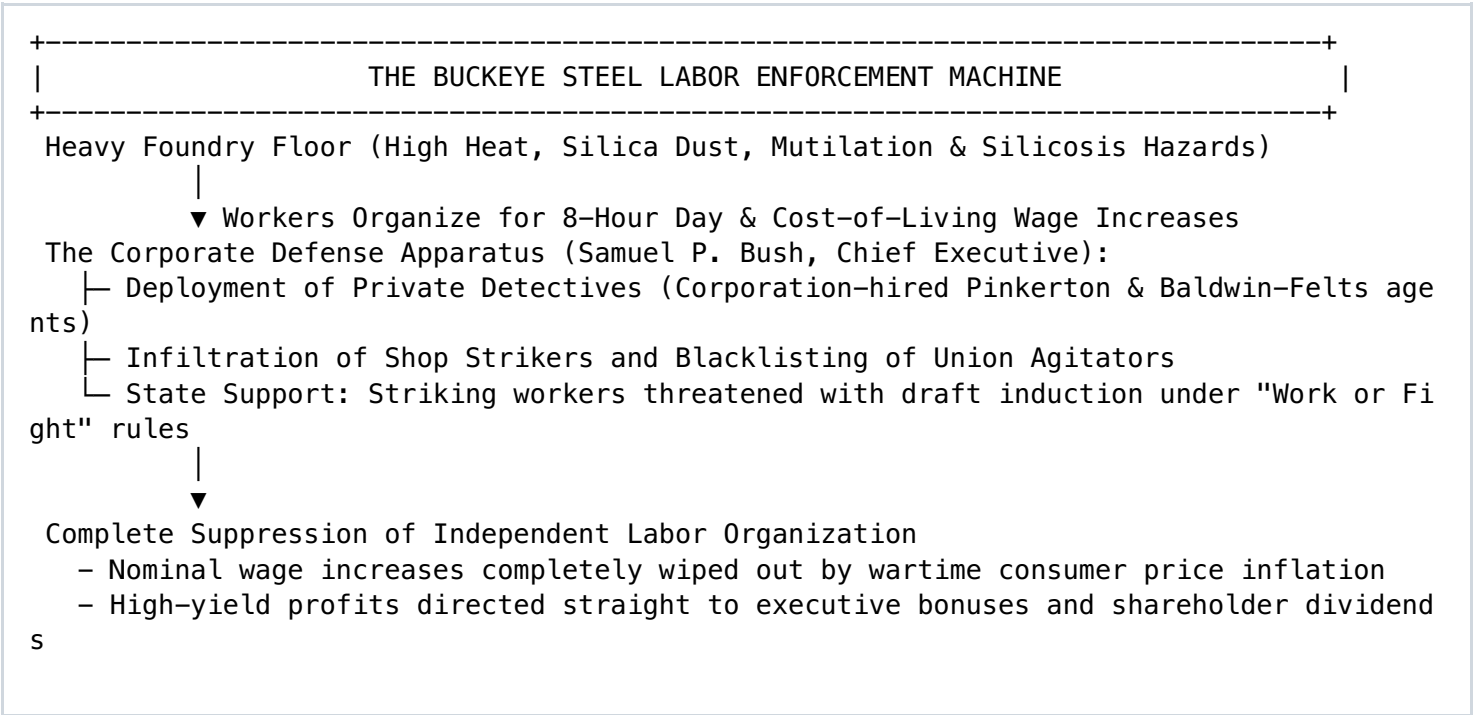
The Eradication of Corporate Risk

While young American doughboys were deployed to the mud of the Meuse-Argonne offensive, facing German mustard gas and heavy machine-gun fire, corporate executives overseen by Samuel P. Bush in Washington operated in a system where business losses were legally impossible.

By eliminating competitive bidding in favor of administrative allocations, the War Industries Board turned the European war into an unprecedented private accumulation of capital in American history.

6. LABOR REPRESSION: INDUSTRIAL ESPIONAGE ON THE FOUNDRY FLOOR

While wartime profits soared, conditions inside heavy foundries like Buckeye Steel in Columbus, Ohio, were grueling and hazardous. Workers operated around 3,000°F open-hearth molten steel furnaces, handling caustic mold chemicals, toxic silica sands, and heavy casting machinery for 12 hours a day, 6 to 7 days a week.



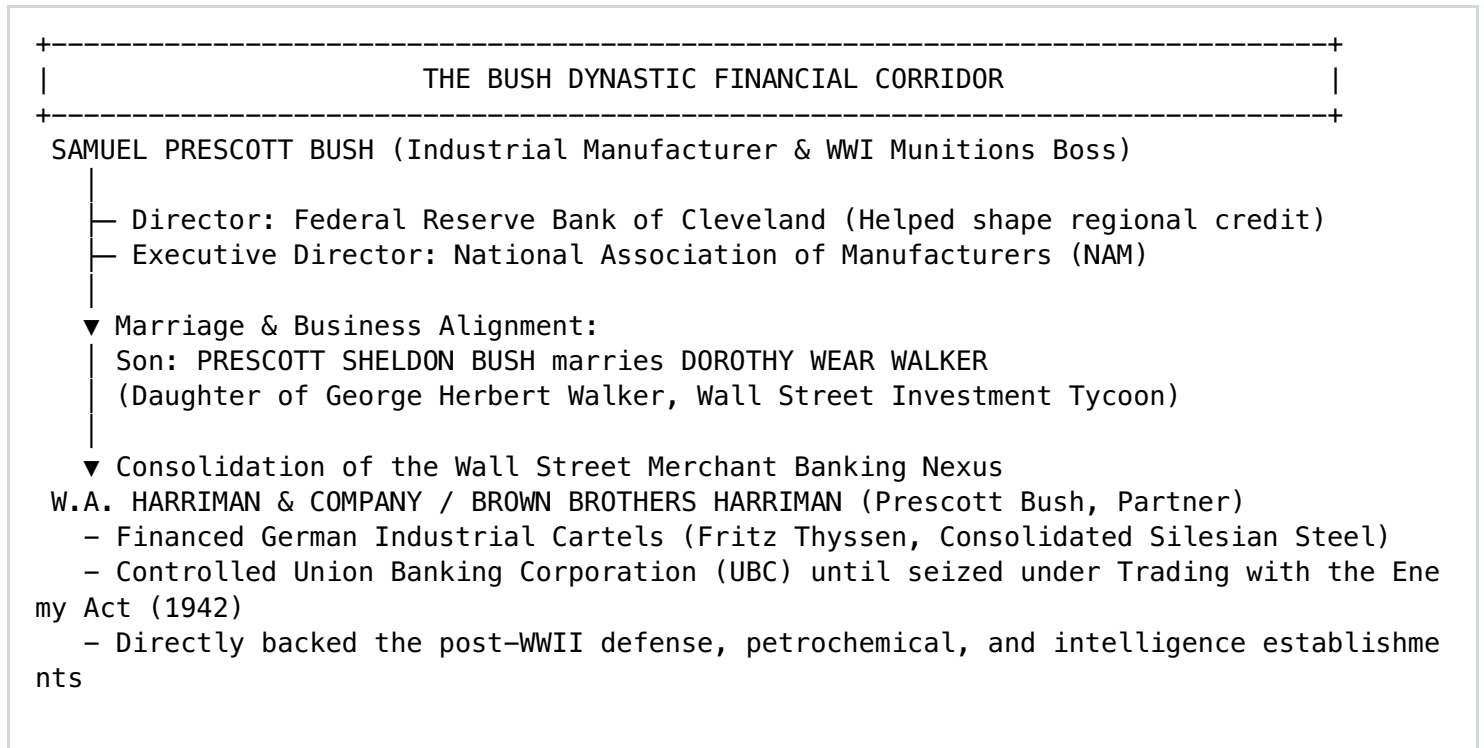
The "Work or Fight" Edict as a Weapon of Capital

In May 1918, the federal government issued the "Work or Fight" order. Any draft-eligible male who was not employed in an "essential war industry" lost his draft exemption and was conscripted directly into the infantry.

Under Samuel P. Bush and his industrial peers, this policy was utilized to suppress strikes. If foundry workers walked out to demand safer casting pits or collective bargaining, management reported the strike leaders to local draft boards, revoking their occupational exemptions and deploying them to frontline combat units in France.

7. THE CONVERGENCE: THE CLEVELAND FED & WALL STREET

The wartime profits accumulated through Buckeye Steel and the War Industries Board did not remain dormant in Columbus. Samuel P. Bush leveraged his wartime relationships with Bernard Baruch and the international banking sector to position his family within the elite financial architecture of the nation.



The Cleveland Federal Reserve Directorship

Following the war, Samuel P. Bush was appointed a director of the **Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland**, integrating his industrial influence into the national banking system. He aligned with the conservative wing of the National Association of Manufacturers (NAM), aggressively fighting New Deal regulations, opposing federal child-labor laws, and pushing to dismantle wartime price controls while protecting corporate tax exemptions.

8. THE NYE COMMITTEE: "MERCHANTS OF DEATH" & MISSING TRAILS

In 1934, amid the depths of the Great Depression, public anger mounted over disclosures that Wall Street banks and industrial munitions corporations had systematically driven the United States into World War I to protect their financial loans and corporate profits.

The United States Senate convened the **Special Committee on Investigation of the Munitions Industry**, chaired by progressive North Dakota Senator **Gerald P. Nye**.

Hearings Before the Special Committee on the Munitions Industry (Nye Committee)

U.S. Senate, 73rd & 74th
Congresses (1934–1936)

"The committee discovered that the munitions makers had engaged in price-fixing, exercised unwholesome influence over government procurement officials, engaged in heavy international lobbying to block disarmament treaties, and derived grotesque profits from the slaughter on European battlefields."

The Missing Records: When investigators attempted to subpoena the day-to-day administrative files and internal transaction ledgers of the War Industries Board's Small Arms and Ammunition Section, key transaction documents were reported lost, destroyed, or unarchived in the post-war transition.

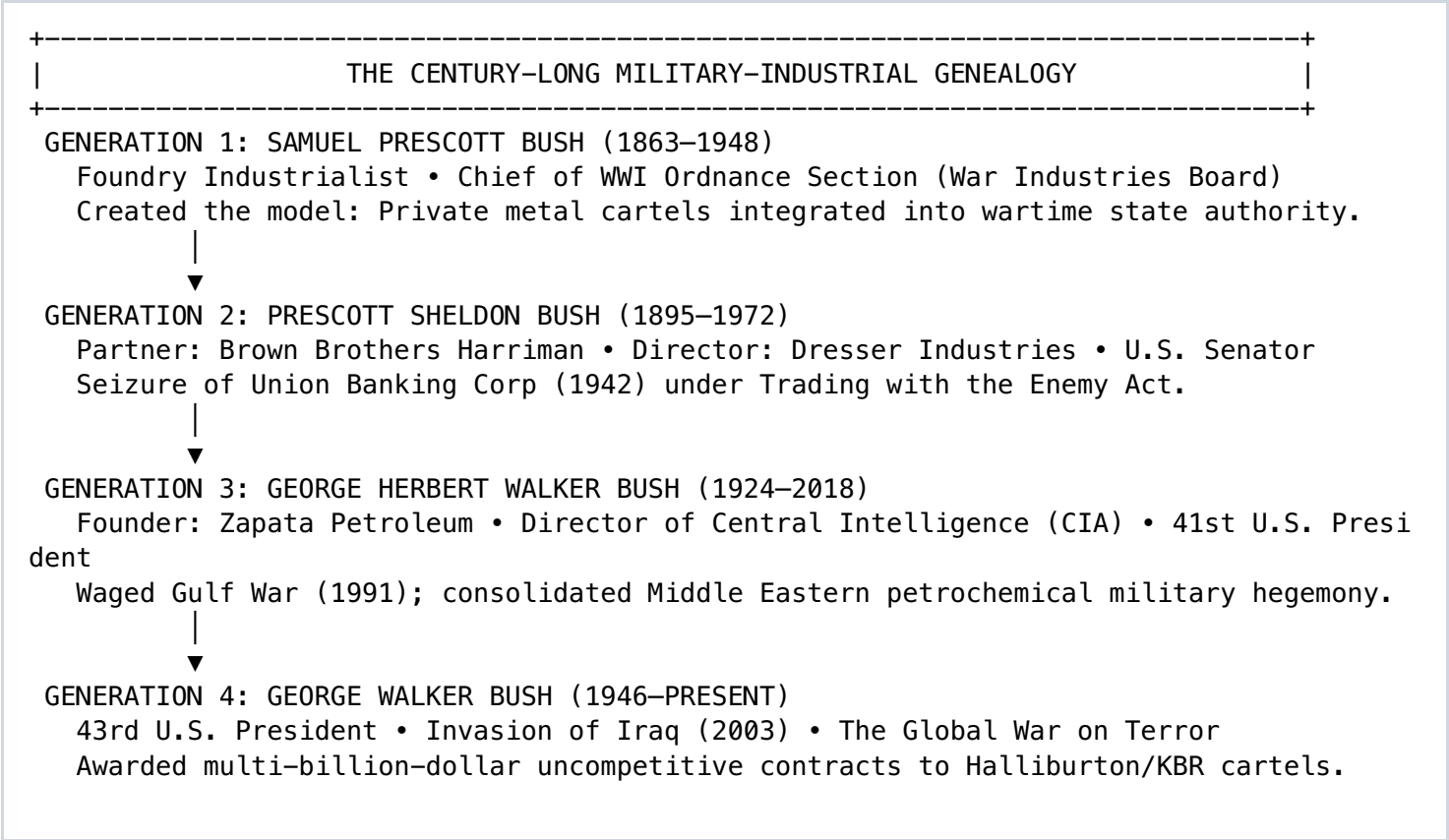
The Institutional Cover-Up

The Nye Committee exposed how corporate executives had stepped into federal uniforms, allocated taxpayer-funded contracts to their own corporate sectors, and then returned to private industry with inflated fortunes.

Though the committee's findings led to the passage of the Neutrality Acts of the 1930s, the underlying structural integration of private steel, arms, and state intelligence networks pioneered by men like Samuel P. Bush and Bernard Baruch was not dismantled—it was consolidated.

9. THE DYNASTIC BLUEPRINT: FROM INDUSTRIAL TO CLANDESTINE EMPIRE

Samuel Prescott Bush’s core historical legacy is not simply the steel he cast; it is the dynastic blueprint he engineered. The marriage of industrial munitions capital, banking networks, and state procurement power laid the groundwork for four generations of political influence:



The Lineage of Conflict Capitalism

From the rail-car couplers of Buckeye Steel and the Enfield rifle contracts of 1918, to the offshore oil concessions of Zapata Petroleum, the covert arms pipelines of Iran-Contra, and the multi-trillion-dollar defense budgets of the Iraq War, the operational pattern remains identical.

The state manufactures a geopolitical crisis; the private corporate network secures non-competitive cost-plus contracts; human casualties are externalized onto the public; and dynastic wealth is preserved behind institutional shields.

10. FORENSIC AUDIT CHECKLIST: DETECTING WAR PROFITEERING NETWORKS

To assist independent investigators, forensic historians, and intelligence researchers tracking corporate-state war racketeering, execute this standardized analytical audit:

- [] **Cross-Index Corporate Boards with Procurement Agencies:** Map corporate executive rosters against active Ministry of Defence / Department of Defense procurement boards to identify revolving-door conflicts of interest.
- [] **Audit Cost-Plus Contract Margins:** Examine procurement ledgers for the presence of non-competitive Cost-Plus-Percentage-of-Cost (CPPC) structures that financially reward contractor cost inflation.
- [] **Trace Upstream Raw Material Monopolies:** Identify whether public officials in charge of weapons standardization hold equity, directorships, or family trusts in upstream steel, chemical, or energy suppliers.
- [] **Investigate Wartime Plant Modernization Subsidies:** Track whether state-funded emergency factory construction grants convert into private corporate-owned balance sheet assets post-conflict.
- [] **Analyze Interlocking Banking Directors:** Map the flow of wartime industrial dividends into private merchant banking houses, offshore trusts, and private investment syndicates.
- [] **Audit Labor Enforcement Mechanisms:** Examine whether state emergency powers (e.g., strike-banning edicts, selective military conscription of labor organizers) are deployed to suppress factory wage demands.
- [] **Examine Archival Destruction Patterns:** Cross-reference missing government procurement receipts with post-war Congressional and parliamentary investigative committee inquiries.